

Case 21: Differences in Work Behavior and Personal Lives
INFO 507 | Assignment 3, part 3 | Professor Poole

Annie McCrone, Emily Greenberg, Victoria Smith, Areej Asiri

Frame the problem

As outlined in part one, we identified four management problems, which we have reiterated below.

Problem	Person(s) involved	Level of Urgency
Communication	Sally, Lee, Charles	Urgent
Performance Management	Lanfen	Urgent
<u>Organizational Culture</u>	<u>All</u>	<u>Very urgent</u>
Ethics	Charles	Not urgent

We believe the most urgent problem to solve is PEC's organizational culture. The company's current culture constrains managerial autonomy, preventing Sally from effectively addressing employee concerns, cross-cultural work differences, and ethical issues within her team. This is the most urgent issue because organizational culture influences leadership behavior, communication practices, and policy enforcement across the company. Addressing the organizational culture at PEC could create broader structural change, allowing Sally greater flexibility to respond to her office's personnel challenges.

Pertinent Facts

- Mandatory years spent in overseas roles places personal strain on employees and their families (PEC has already lost employees to this stress)
- Sally is consistently overwhelmed by Lee's communication method ("Here we go again")
- Lee and Lanfen's differing cultural backgrounds are contributing to a clash in work styles, hindering overall productivity
- Charles's comments are inappropriate and unprofessional ("control his wife," "get your people in line")
- Sally perceives Lanfen's hiring as being strongly based on recommendation from the Consulate General

Courses of Action

1. Escalate organizational culture concerns to senior leadership

Sally is facing multiple issues – Lee's Thompson's family stress, Lanfen Benson's work style conflict, and the dismissive responses from HR. These could be viewed as isolated personnel problems; however, they can also be presented as symptoms of a broader organizational culture issue. PEC's hierarchical structure limits Sally's autonomy as a manager, and she needs the support of senior leadership to address any of these issues.

To escalate the issue appropriately, Sally should gather evidence to support a claim that PEC's rigid policies raise organizational culture concerns related to employee retention, consistency across international offices, and leadership practices. Evidence can include documentation of employee turnover rate related to the mandatory overseas assignments and emails or written records of communication breakdowns and workplace conflicts. Presenting the multitude of problems as an organizational culture issue shifts the conversation away from the individual complaints and towards solutions that allow Sally to make effective decisions in her role.

Sally could request a formal meeting with HR including senior leadership. In this meeting, she would present her concerns about the company's cultural expectations surrounding overseas assignments and her limited autonomy as manager. Advocating for leadership to reconsider long-standing policies would be a bold step and carries both potential advantages and risks.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Brings organizational culture issues to the attention of senior leadership, increasing the possibility of long-term policy changes.	Sally risks damaging her professional relationship with the HR Vice President by appearing to bypass his authority.
Demonstrates leadership initiative by addressing organizational issues rather than ignoring them.	Long - term policy changes take time and resources to implement.

Evaluation: The success of this course of action depends heavily on the willingness of senior leadership to acknowledge and address these issues. Because PEC operates within a hierarchical structure, Sally's ability to influence organizational culture at the executive level may be limited.

Consequence	Likelihood of Occurrence
Organizational culture concerns reach senior leadership	80% - Sally can schedule a meeting & present evidence
Potential for long-term policy change	30 % - dependent on leadership's willingness to change
Demonstrates leadership initiative	90% - Sally is actively addressing systemic issues
Damaged relationship with HR Vice President	60% - possible if escalation is perceived as bypassing authority
Leadership resistance to change	70% - likely due to existing hierarchical structure and established policies

2. Implement specific communication policies for Sally's team

One solution could be to implement specific communication policies within Sally's team. For example, she could create standard workflows and expectations and cascade those policies to relevant stakeholders such as Lee Thompson. Perhaps one policy could be that she will respond to certain types of requests and complaints on a specific timeline, which could dissuade Lee from

sending barrages of emails reiterating the same issue he's having. Furthermore, maybe she institutes best practices for in-office communication and includes lists of inappropriate language to avoid. This could theoretically prevent Charles from profusing misogynistic comments and berating Sally. Finally, Sally could request written policy regarding the hiring process via a vis Consulate recommendations. This would prevent her from misinterpreting whether she has to hire someone (i.e. Lanfen).

Advantages	Disadvantages
Clearly documented policies remove ambiguity	May take a while to implement and cascade
Prevents inappropriate behavior	Could lead to disgruntled employees

Evaluation: The biggest advantage of clear communication policies is that it removes ambiguity, and allows managers to point to documentation to support their decisions. However, a significant potential drawback is it may take a while to implement and cascade such policies. While it would be fastest for Sally to decide the policies herself, in reality she will likely need input and support from higher ups and feedback from subordinates. This may be better viewed as a long-term solution.

Furthermore, while communication policies can prevent inappropriate behavior in theory, they may not in practice. This means this 'advantage' may not be a real one. Furthermore, the policies could lead to disgruntled employees, particularly if they disagree with certain policies or if they feel they were not consulted for input. Overall, while clearer communication policies are a necessity, it is not what we chose to focus on as the best and immediate solution.

Consequence	Likelihood of occurrence
Removal of ambiguity	85% (likely, though there were always been conflicting interpretations of policies)
Prevents inappropriate behavior	50% (maybe in theory, but not in practice; hard to know for sure)
Takes a long time to implement	90% (very likely given amount of feedback and approval needed)
Disgruntled employees	60% (hard to determine, but given issues seems more likely than not)

3. Providing training for employees & standardizing workflows

The conflict between Lee Thompson and Lanfen Benson reflects differences in professional practice rather than a clear performance issue. Lanfen's reliance on written documentation reflects the professional norms of where she was trained - in Indonesia. Lee, however, expects employees to rely primarily on PEC's digital systems and the different approaches are leading to frustration and misinterpretation of work behaviors in the office. To address this issue, PEC could standardize workflow expectations while also providing training programs that help bridge the organization's policies with the cultural norms of international offices.

Programs could include workshops on how PEC's information systems are intended to function, and training for managers on how to support employees who come from different professional backgrounds. Once training resources are established, Sally could work with HR and training specialists to implement these programs within the Abu Dhabi office and potentially across other overseas locations. Implementing cross-cultural coaching and standardized training presents both advantages and disadvantages:

Advantages	Disadvantages
Provides employees with clearer guidance on PEC's workflow expectations	Behavioral changes resulting from training may take time to appear.
Helps managers and employees better understand cultural differences in professional practices and communication styles.	Requires time and organizational resources to develop and implement training programs.
Can be implemented within Sally's managerial authority in collaboration with HR and training specialists.	Does not address structural or ethics concerns within the department.

Evaluation: Training offers a practical solution that directly addresses the conflict between Lee Thompson and Lanfen Benson. This approach focuses on clarifying expectations and supporting employees who come from different cultural backgrounds. This course of action can be implemented at the managerial level with support from HR. While training may not resolve structural issues within PEC, it provides an immediate and realistic step toward reducing workplace conflict in the overseas offices.

Consequence	Likelihood of Occurrence
Clearer workflow expectations for employees	85% - Training programs typically clarify procedures and expectations
Improved understanding of cultural work differences	75% - Training often improves awareness but may not eliminate conflict entirely
Training requires organizational resources	80% - HR must develop materials for new programs
Changes take time	70% - Employees need time to adapt to new expectations

4. Report and address inappropriate workplace conduct through HR channels

One option open to Sally is working through PEC's HR structure to escalate concerns about inappropriate behavior or personnel issues with other individuals, namely Charles and Lee. Charles's inappropriate comments and dismissive attitude, especially towards women, merits escalation up the management chain. Lee's and his wife's dissatisfaction with living in Abu Dhabi may be better handled through HR processes than by Sally's management authority. Additionally, Sally's concerns about any unfairness or pressure involved in Lanfen's hiring can be brought to HR to investigate their own policies and procedures.

To pursue this option, similar to Option 1 above, Sally can start by gathering evidence about the situations and the parties involved. She can provide copies of email exchanges with Lee, and any additional relevant emails she has with Charles or Lanfen, as well as document her in-person interactions with Charles and pull together evidence of the concerns she has around Lanfen's hiring. Armed with this evidence, Sally could request a meeting with members of the HR team to discuss her concerns. Given that parts of this issue involve Charles's inappropriate behavior, she should reach out directly and specifically to HR team members whom she trusts to review the situation with professional distance, and who will ensure word of her escalation doesn't get back to Charles before they're ready for him to hear about it.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Redirects concerns to a team better equipped to handle them (HR as opposed to Sally as an individual)	Potential conflict of interest with Charles as VP of HR; may be perceived as going over his head
Leaves clear documentation of Sally's involvement and decisions	Sally may lack trust in an HR team which has Charles in a leadership role
	Issues are likely to be dealt with individually, without addressing broader problems of organizational culture

Evaluation: HR is meant to be a resource for managers and employees in difficult interpersonal situations, and Sally isn't a trained HR professional. Working more formally with HR both removes the issues from Sally's personal plate and provides evidence for senior leadership that she's following standard protocols for dealing with them. However, bringing up issues with the VP of HR with his own team is likely to be a tense situation, so Sally may not have strong incentive to trust she'll get a meaningful resolution by working through the established channels. Additionally, HR's involvement is likely to address what Sally brings them as a series of separate interpersonal problems if at all, working through each case with the individuals involved, rather than seeing them as symptoms of a broader organizational culture problem and treating the

source. If she wants to see lasting organizational change at PEC to prevent similar behavior in the future, Sally may be better served by pursuing other options.

Consequence	Likelihood of Occurrence
Redirects concerns to more appropriate team	60% - Individual workplace behavior is more properly an HR matter than Sally's responsibility, though in the long run she may still have to deal with it
Leaves a clear paper trail of Sally's actions	90% - Submitting a formal grievance or otherwise requesting intervention from HR should almost certainly be documented
Conflict with Charles	70% - Depending on the HR team's structure and how they handle the situation, there's a good chance Charles will at least be upset by Sally's report, based on his described personality
Lack of trust in HR team based on Charles's involvement	70% - Even if Sally opts to go with this option, she's not likely to have full confidence in PEC's HR team, given Charles's example
Failure to address broader organizational concerns	80% - One-time intervention from HR with specific employees is not likely to create lasting, sweeping changes in company culture

5. Maintain status quo and enforce existing policies

There is always an option to 'do nothing' in favor of maintaining the status quo and enforcing existing policies. While this may seem like not a real solution, it is too often a course of action that companies take in the face of mounting issues. Here we examine whether this would be effective in this case.

Advantages	Disadvantages
No cost	Allows issues to snowball
No uncomfortable discussions	Future 'solutions' could require more drastic measures

Evaluation: While the advantages of ‘no cost’ and ‘no uncomfortable discussions’ sound positive, these are short-sighted advantages. If nothing is addressed, the issues could snowball into problems that require solutions with greater cost and even more uncomfortable discussions. Therefore, it does not make sense to choose maintaining the status quo as a way to address the organizational culture.

Consequence	Likelihood of occurrence
No cost	0% (will lead to future costs)
No uncomfortable discussions	0% (will lead to future conversations)
Issues will snowball	85% (very likely unaddressed problems will escalate)
Future solutions are more expensive and severe	50% (hard to determine because it depends on whether issues get worse and by how much)

Best option: #3. *Providing training for employees & standardizing workflows*

Standardizing workflows and providing cross-cultural coaching appears to be the most tangible and realistic solution to some of the problems Sally is facing. The other courses of action require significant organizational changes or approval from senior leadership. This option can be implemented at the managerial level. Sally can work directly with HR to clarify PEC’s workflow procedures and ensure that expectations regarding documentation, communication, and use of digital systems are clearly defined. Roles like Lee’s already exist to enforce established policies, meaning that the structure needed to support standardized practices is already in place.

Teamwork Strategies

As a whole, our team adhered to the plan of study outlined in the first week of class as our primary method of coordinating the time aspect of the course. Each time a phase of the project or an assignment deadline approached, we communicated with each other through our group chat to determine a date/time to meet and discuss the next steps of the project. At each meeting, we reviewed the requirements of the phase of the project we were moving into and assigned the individual tasks among the team members. The group agreed upon internal due dates for completion of each task. As a result of this coordination strategy, the entire group remained on track and submitted each phase of the project on time and did not miss a single deadline. After we established the individual tasks associated with each phase of the project, each group member was permitted to select the area of the project they were most interested in completing. This strategy promoted accountability, enthusiasm, and responsibility among the group members since each member chose a portion of the project they wanted to focus on. Although the group was flexible during the entire project, if a member experienced difficulty completing their

assigned portion of the project, they were willing to swap portions of the project or assist fellow members. Ultimately, the combination of individual preferences and group assistance fostered an enjoyable collaborative atmosphere within the team.

Communication was clearly the most important aspect of our teamwork. We communicated regularly to ensure we were all in agreement and knew what we needed to do next. The continuous communication facilitated effective cooperation, assistance when challenges arose, and ultimately completion of all the assignments within the given time frame. Therefore, by placing emphasis on communication, our group functioned as a unified and productive unit.

The following key factors contributed to the success of our group work. All members maintained communication with each other, which enabled them to remain informed and involved. Respect and sensitivity toward each other's schedules and needs fostered a supportive, relaxed environment. All group members were willing to assist each other when needed. Early planning and clear division of labor ensured that all of the project tasks were organized appropriately from the outset. Open discussion among group members enhanced the quality of the project because diverse viewpoints improved the outcome overall. Although the overall experience was positive, as with all experiences, there are opportunities to continue improving. If we utilize a more formalized tracking tool to monitor our progress in future group projects, we will have more visibility into each member's contribution to the project.